

At the edge of a quiet forest, where the trees opened into a wide green meadow, there was a small pond. It was not a particularly impressive pond. It had no waterfall, no great river flowing into it, and no name that appeared on any map. But to a little green frog named Moss, it was the most important place in the world.

Moss had lived there for as long as he could remember.

In spring, the pond filled with tadpoles that darted between the reeds like tiny black fish. In summer, blue dragonflies skimmed across the water. Beetles hid beneath the stones, and tall yellow flowers grew along the muddy shore.

Moss knew every corner of the pond. He knew which stone stayed warm longest after sunset and which lily pad was strong enough to hold two frogs at once. He knew where the mosquitoes gathered in the evening and where the water was deepest when the days became hot.

Most of all, Moss loved the rain.

Whenever dark clouds appeared above the forest, he climbed onto his favorite stone and waited for the first drop to fall.

But one summer, the rain stopped.

At first, nobody worried.

"It will rain tomorrow," said an old brown frog who lived beneath the reeds.

But tomorrow came without rain.

Then another day passed.

And another.

The sun remained high in a perfectly blue sky.

After several weeks, the pond began to shrink.

The muddy shoreline moved farther inward every day. The grass around the pond turned yellow, and the earth became hard and cracked. The dragonflies disappeared. Even the mosquitoes became difficult to find.

The frogs gathered one evening beside the remaining water.

"We should leave," said the old brown frog. "There is a river beyond the northern trees. It will still have water."

Several frogs immediately agreed.

Moss looked across the pond. It was smaller than he had ever seen it, but it was still his home.

"I think I'll stay," he said.

The other frogs stared at him.

"You cannot wait forever," said one.

"It will rain," Moss replied.

The next morning, the frogs began their journey north.

Moss watched them disappear into the tall grass until he could no longer hear their hopping.

For the first time in his life, the pond was completely silent.

Days passed.

Moss tried to continue as usual. Every morning, he sat on his favorite stone. Every afternoon, he rested beneath the reeds.

But there were fewer reeds now.

Eventually, the pond became little more than a muddy puddle beneath a large fern.

Moss began to wonder if he had made a terrible mistake.

One afternoon, he decided to search the forest for water.

He had never travelled far from the pond before.

Everything beneath the trees seemed enormous. Fallen branches became walls that he had to climb. Tree roots twisted across the ground like giant snakes. Every unfamiliar sound made Moss stop and listen.

After travelling for what felt like hours, he heard something rustling nearby.

Moss froze.

A large shadow moved behind a fallen log.

Then a hedgehog appeared.

The hedgehog looked at Moss.

Moss looked at the hedgehog.

"Are you lost?" asked the hedgehog.

"No," said Moss quickly.

The hedgehog waited.

"Maybe a little," Moss admitted.

He explained that his pond was disappearing and that he was looking for water.

"There is a river north of here," said the hedgehog. "You could reach it before tomorrow."

Moss knew that must be the same river the other frogs had travelled to.

"Is it far?"

"For a frog? Very."

Moss looked back toward the forest behind him.

He could continue north. He could find the other frogs and live beside the river.

But something made him turn around.

"Thank you," Moss said. "I think I'm going home."

The hedgehog seemed surprised but wished him luck.

By sunset, Moss reached his pond again.

Only the smallest puddle remained.

That night, Moss sat beside it and looked at the stars reflected in the shallow water.

"Perhaps tomorrow," he whispered.

Another week passed.

Then one evening, something changed.

The forest became strangely quiet.

Moss noticed that the air felt cooler against his skin. The leaves high above him began to move, although there had been no wind all day.

He climbed onto his favorite stone.

Far beyond the trees, the sky was no longer blue.

Dark clouds were gathering.

Moss watched them slowly cover the stars.

Then he felt something cold land between his eyes.

A drop of water.

Moss did not move.

Another drop landed beside him.

Then another.

Suddenly, the sky opened.

Rain crashed through the trees.

Water poured from leaves and ran between the roots. The hard earth became dark with moisture. Tiny streams formed across the meadow and rushed toward the empty pond.

Moss jumped from his stone.

He hopped through the rain, splashing through every puddle he could find.

The pond began to fill.

The little puddle became a pool.

The pool spread toward the reeds.

By morning, water once again surrounded Moss's favorite stone.

For the first time in weeks, the forest was filled with sound.

Birds sang from the trees. Insects appeared above the water. Moss sat in the middle of the pond and croaked as loudly as he could.

Several days later, Moss heard familiar voices coming from the meadow.

The frogs had returned.

They hopped toward the pond one after another, amazed to find it full again.

The old brown frog climbed onto a stone beside Moss.

"You really stayed here the entire time?"

Moss thought about the dry weeks.

He thought about the disappearing water, the journey into the forest, and the river he had almost followed.

"Almost," he said.

The old frog laughed.

That evening, the frogs gathered around the pond as the sun disappeared behind the trees. Dragonflies had already returned, and the water reflected the orange sky.

Moss sat on his favorite stone.

He had always believed that waiting meant simply staying where you were.

Now he understood that it was something different.

Sometimes waiting meant wondering if you were wrong.

Sometimes it meant being afraid.

And sometimes it meant walking almost all the way toward something new before deciding that there was still something worth returning to.

Moss looked across the pond.

Somewhere far away, thunder rolled again.

This time, he smiled.